The world may be saying it now and the India Today Conclave may have made it its theme in 2023, but Prime Minister Narendra Modi had heralded 'The India Moment' 20 months ago, from the ramparts of the Red Fort on August 15, 2021. "This is the time, and it is the right time," he had said. And as he took the stage at the India Today Conclave on March 18, this is what he reminded the audience before him, both at the Taj Palace Hotel in Delhi, as well as those watching him on television or digitally.

Presiding over this India Moment and helping it become a reality has been none other than the prime minister himself. As India Today Group Chairman and Editor-in-chief Aroon Purie perceptively pointed out in his opening comments to the prime minister's session, while his officers are still collecting the dots, Prime Minister Modi has already gone ahead and connected the dots. This farsightedness and hard work have been the hallmark of the nine years he has been at the country's helm, even as he and his party gear up for a third term in the 2024 general election.

It was with this conviction that the prime minister rose to speak at the conclave. India's achievements, he said, are all the more exemplary because they have come in the midst of unusual challenges—"the biggest epidemic in the last 100 years!"—followed by a war between two countries. That there should be an India Moment despite this meant "new history being made", he said.

Thus it is, the PM said, that India is today the world's fastest-growing economy, its leading smartphone data consumer, second-largest mobile manufacturer, third-largest start-up ecosystem and No. 1 in global fintech adoption. Reminding the audience how his government had been working all through the 75 days it had completed in 2023, the PM reeled out an entire litany of projects that had been onboarded in this time, from a historic green budget to the inauguration of the India-Bangladesh gas pipeline. "The list of 75 days is so long, we'll run out of time," he said.

India was powering ahead not just with building physical infrastructure such as roads, railways, ports and airports, but also its soft power. There is global recognition for Yoga, Ayurveda, Indian cuisine, culture and even its films today. Just days before his address, the song 'Naatu Naatu' and the documentary *The Elephant Whisperers* had won an



The world can see that a democratically elected government is taking decisions in India. The country is filled with self-confidence, foreign countries as well as foreign experts are optimistic about India. In the middle of all this, talk of pessimism, attempts to degrade India, lower the willpower of the people is taking place. It's like the tradition of putting a 'kala tika' to ward off evil